A Model of Christian Charity

John Winthrop · 1630 (aboard the Arbella)

Source: John Winthrop, A Modell of Christian Charity (1630), text via Hanover College Historical Texts Project. Public domain; original 1630 spelling retained.

John Winthrop, first governor of the Massachusetts Bay Colony, delivered this lay sermon to fellow Puritans crossing the Atlantic. He described their colony as a covenant with God and a model for the world — the famous "city upon a hill." The sermon captures the religious mission, communal ideals, and sense of exceptional purpose that shaped New England society, in sharp contrast to the profit-driven Chesapeake.

Connect: How did the Puritans' religious purpose differ from the economic motives driving the founding of the Chesapeake colonies?

Key Passages

A covenant with God

> Thus stands the cause betweene God and us. We are entered into Covenant with Him for this worke. … Now if the Lord shall please to heare us, and bring us in peace to the place we desire, then hath hee ratified this covenant and sealed our Commission, and will expect a strict performance of the articles contained in it; … but if wee shall neglect the observation of these articles which are the ends wee have propounded, … seeking greate things for ourselves and our posterity, the Lord will surely breake out in wrathe against us;

Knit together as one

> wee must be knitt together, in this worke, as one man. Wee must entertaine each other in brotherly affection. … Wee must delight in eache other; make other's conditions our oune; rejoice together, mourne together, labour and suffer together, allwayes haueving before our eyes our commission and community in the worke, as members of the same body.

A city upon a hill

> For wee must consider that wee shall be as a citty upon a hill. The eies of all people are uppon us. … Soe that if wee shall deale falsely with our God in this worke wee haue undertaken, and soe cause him to withdrawe his present help from us, wee shall be made a story and a by-word through the world.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Great Migration of Puritans to New England (1630s): Puritans who wanted to purify the Church of England left for Massachusetts Bay to build a godly community.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Fellow Puritan colonists on board the Arbella and the fleet sailing to Massachusetts Bay.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	John Winthrop, a lawyer, devout Puritan, and the colony's first governor, who saw the colony as a covenant with God and wanted to keep its members united and obedient.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE way Puritan beliefs shaped the development of New England society.
2. What does the phrase “city upon a hill” reveal about the Puritans’ sense of purpose?
3. How might this vision create tension for dissenters such as Roger Williams or Anne Hutchinson?